05 | RESPECTFUL REVERSAL | RESOURCE

How to Reverse a Decision Respectfully

Five steps for explaining a change while keeping roles clear

Sometimes new facts mean a decision has to change. A good conversation helps people understand why and keep working with confidence. Use these steps when you change direction within your authority, or when you explain a change that someone else approved.

01	**Recognize** State the original decision and what was known at the time. Acknowledge the person's reasoning. Confirm the facts before you say the decision was authorized or reasonable.
02	**Explain** Describe the new information, service risk, or limit that requires the change. Keep the focus on the work, not on the person.
03	**Own** Take responsibility for your part in both the original direction and the new one. Don't shift blame to staff or pass along a change without explaining it.
04	**Direct** Explain what happens next, when, who does it, and what support is available. Point out any decision that still needs someone with authority.
05	**Clarify** Say whether the change applies only to this situation or to a wider process. Don't present a one-time fix as a new rule.

When you are on the receiving end

Ask about any step that wasn't explained. Repeat back what you will do, what you can still decide, and who will support you. When you share the change with others, don't add blame or change its meaning.

> **Respectful and accountable**
> A respectful explanation does not skip a required review. It keeps the facts, expectations, support, and responsibilities clear while the work is corrected.

Source: Safe to Decide training, Supervisor edition, slides 23–25.

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Respectful Reversal Example and Planner

Made-up example: a confirmed coverage gap means today's assignments must change for one day.

Step	What you could say
1. Recognize	"You planned today's work using the coverage schedule we confirmed."
2. Explain	"We now have a coverage gap during the afternoon service window, so we need to change today's assignments."
3. Own	"It's my job to make the new plan clear and help the team carry it out."
4. Direct	"Please use the revised assignment this afternoon. I'll help let the team know and confirm support before the service window starts."
5. Clarify	"This change is for today only. Tomorrow's schedule and the usual approval process stay the same."

Plan your conversation

Use this space	Your notes
Original decision and facts	
New information and reason	
My responsibility	
Next step and support	
One situation or a wider rule?	

Check that the message was understood

Ask: "What will you do next, and what support do you still need?" Then confirm who will tell anyone else affected, and whether a written CCE message or an updated document is needed.

Source: Safe to Decide training, Supervisor edition, slides 23–25.